one. Based on several such initiatives and outcomes, Mizoram improved its ranking in the SDG index from 21 in 2019-20 to 12 in 2020-21.

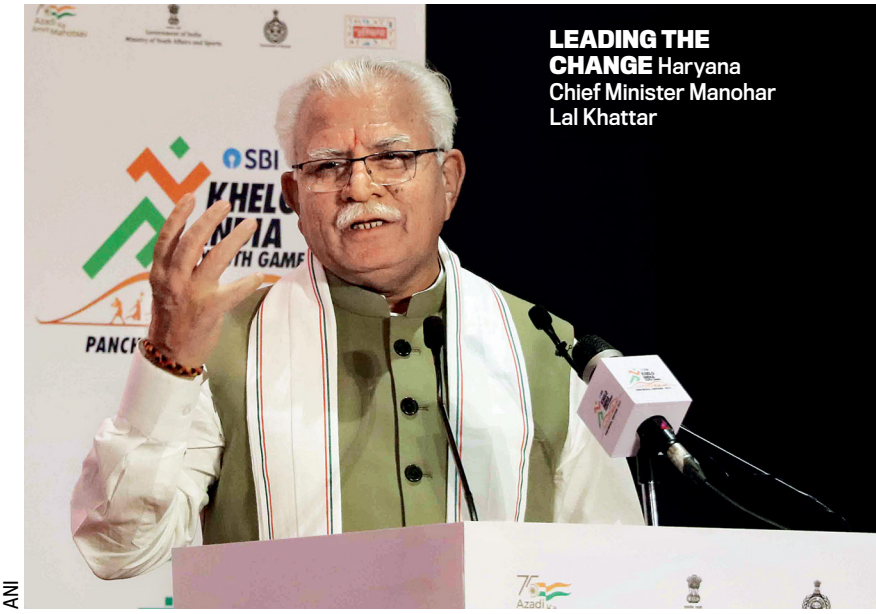
Most Improved Big State: Bihar

Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar, the longest serving in the state's history has a clear priority when it comes to development programmes—they need to be inclusive, equitable and must focus on the most marginalised sections. It assumes importance as close to 90 per cent of the state's population lives in rural areas. Soon after taking over Bihar's reins for the first time in November 2005, Nitish had launched Jeevika, a programme that aimed to improve livelihoods of the rural poor by developing institutions, such as self-help groups (SHGs), for women. Over the years, Kumar's brainchild has registered a massive success, with nearly 13 million rural women and a million SHGs attached to it, and providing a whopping Rs 16,536 crore of bank credit. During Covid-19, the Bihar government also added more than two million beneficiaries to the PDS network, showing its commitment to the most vulnerable sections.

Most Improved Small State: Goa

The Pramod Sawant government is pumping in resources for poverty alleviation, while working on improving multiple indices. The state is giving its citizens access to cleaner fuel—the ratio of domestic LPG and PNG consumers to the total number of households is 1.54. It means some houses have more than one piped gas or cylinder connection. The average daily wage of Goans is Rs 315, best among the small states and overall second only to Haryana (Rs 328). As far as housing is concerned, for every 10,000 built in 2020-21, 782 were for the poor under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana Gramin. ■

–Amarnath K. Menon, Kaushik Deka, Amitabh Srivastava and Anilesh S. Mahajan



ANI

LEADING THE CHANGE Haryana Chief Minister Manohar Lal Khattar

CATEGORY WINNERS **ENTREPRENEURSHIP**

THE LOCAL REVOLUTION

Homegrown entrepreneurs flourish as states like Haryana nurture the start-up spirit



With states competing for investment, setting up a business-friendly ecosystem has become crucial for success. Alongside, a case is also being made for homegrown entrepreneurs. The states who have seen success in the entrepreneurship stakes are the ones that have married concepts such as ease of doing business index, Start-up India, Skill India, and increased Mudra Bank credit fund disbursals.

Best Performing Big State: Haryana

In July this year, Haryana came up with a plan to build an ecosystem to encourage manufacturing across the state via its 'one block, one product' programme. All 137 blocks in the state were encouraged to work out a system to provide financial and technical assistance for at least one product. This could be a game-changer and revive the traditional hub for textiles in Panipat, food processing in the countryside of Hisar, etc. CMIE data shows unemployment figures of 29.3 per cent for the state, though Chief Minister M.L. Khattar rubbishes the methodology used. "We have our own verified data of almost all households in the state," says the CM. "We are providing not only opportunities for jobs, but also trying to create entrepreneurs. Our ministry of commerce and industries data shows that we had 2.2 start-